

► **Female figurine**

This stone figurine from Jaina, Mexico, dating back to 600–900 CE, is believed to depict a sea goddess. The abundance of surviving female figurines from Mesoamerican art has led scholars to suggest that such objects were often made by women for use in worship in the home.

an artificial nose bridge, while for the second they tied small balls to their hair to dangle in front of their eyes. The third involved deforming a child's forehead in infancy by tying wooden boards to it. Analysis of skulls found at Yaxuna, in Yucatán, Mexico, showed that this cranial manipulation was performed more often on women than men.

Despite their attention to looks, marriages were not based on love or physical attraction. The collective outweighed the individual, meaning that marriage was not just a union of two people but the basis of a contract between two kin groups or city-states. Marriages always took place after both parties had reached puberty, when a woman was in her late teens or early 20s. For the first few years, the couple lived with the wife's parents, before setting up their own independent household near to the husband's parents. Widows could remarry, but there was no ceremony for remarriages. A man simply went to the house of the woman he wished to marry; if she fed him, it meant that she accepted him as her new husband.

"[K'ABEL] WAS
MARRIED OFF FOR
THE **GREATER GOOD**
OF AN **ALLIANCE**."

TRACI ARDREN ON THE DISCOVERY OF K'ABEL'S TOMB

